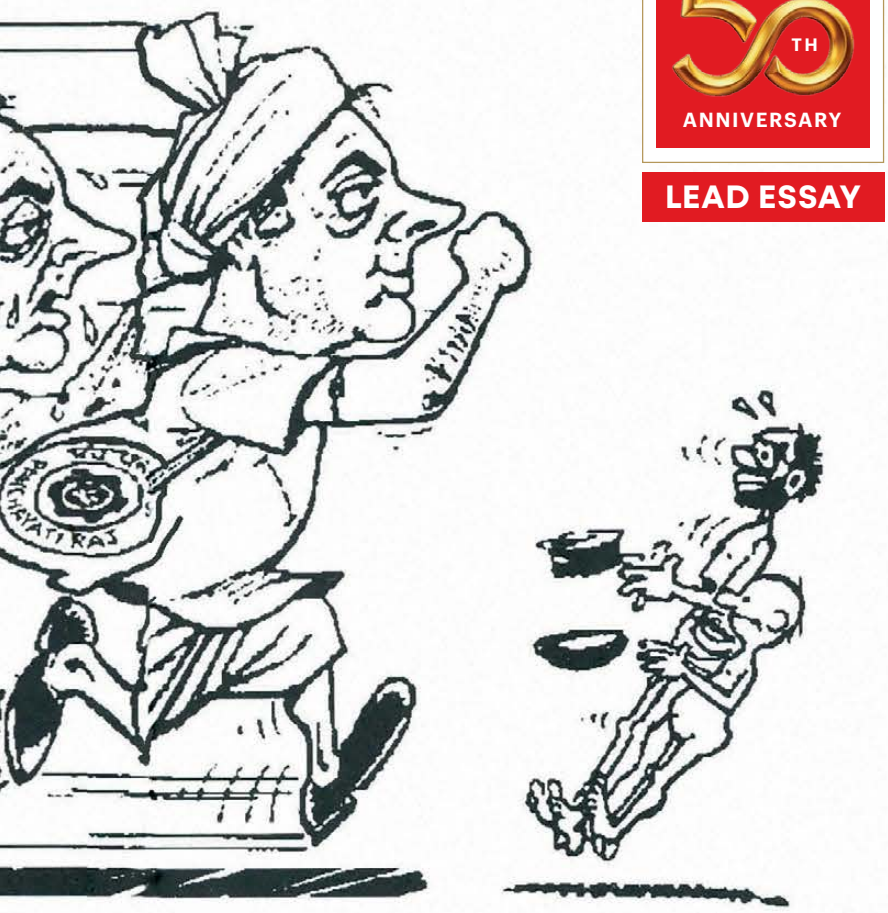


instability, communal and caste divides, decline of a stabilising dynasty, nuclear and terrorist threats, social upheavals, loss of the most trusted ally (Soviet Union)—came true in this decade is one side of the coin. How India responded, learning to trust coalitions, reforming its economy, repositioning itself strategically and leveraging its human resources, is the other. India emerged much stronger, more confident and with a rising global presence.

Through these years, INDIA TODAY was at the heart of this transformation and often in the front. The first enduring reform for the generations since 1985 was Rajiv Gandhi's push for computers. The first computers for an Indian newsroom, a pair of boxy Apple desktops arrived in 1985. These were given an exclusive cabin even in a newsroom so constrained for space.

There was a crush for keyboard-time as we discovered the freedom from finger-wrecking manual typewriters and the assurance of the floppy disc. Soon enough, Dilip Bobb, who did the most editing and rewriting, staked one out for himself—or at least pretended to—by having Shirley Joshua, incredible pivot of the process-driven back-end, create a little placard that read, 'This is the Apple of my Eye', and plonked it on one desktop. That line of control was violated even more frequently and recklessly as than the one up north by the bad guys. Since we remember the turning points in our lives, high or low by association, the first story I wrote on one of these desktops was the initial controversy over the Mandal Commission report in 1985. That story endures four decades on.

L.K. Advani's rath yatra and, ultimately, the Babri Masjid demolition in December 1992 unleashed communal riots across states. Among the bloodiest were in Bombay and the crowded, slummified small towns on its periphery. In its wake came the serial blasts targeting key commercial buildings and neighbourhoods. This wasn't India's first trial with a serial bombing. The capital had had some, following the Punjab troubles and the massacre of Sikhs. But not at

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